The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Iran hit a second **American plane**, according to reports citing American officials. The A-10 Warthog aircraft went down near the Strait of Hormuz; its pilot was rescued safely. The incident reportedly happened around the same time that an F-15E jet was shot over **Iran**—the first such downing since the war began. One crew member was rescued and another remains missing.

America's economy added 178,000 jobs in March, much more than expected. The Bureau of Labour Statistics also revised down February's figure from a loss of 92,000 to one of 133,000, underscoring recent volatility in the jobs market. Traders now expect the Federal Reserve to leave interest rates unchanged this year as it assesses the effects of the Iran war on inflation.

The Trump administration said it would ask for a significant rise in **defence spending** in its **budget request** to Congress for the 2027 fiscal year. The request includes $1.5trn in military funding, a rise of more than 40% compared with the previous year. The administration said it would partly offset the increase with cuts of $73bn to non-military spending.

Israel struck Beirut, **Lebanon's** capital. The Israel Defence Forces hit what they said were Hizbullah-linked sites in the city's southern

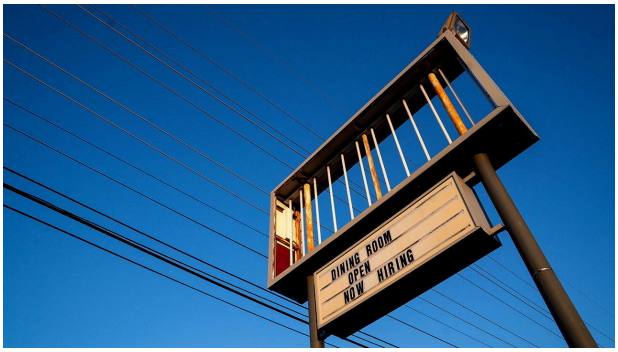
suburbs, after ordering evacuations in several neighbourhoods. The strikes come as Israel presses on with its offensive in southern Lebanon. Meanwhile America urged its citizens to leave Lebanon, warning that Iran may target American-linked universities.

Russia launched large air strikes across Ukraine, according to the Ukrainian air force. The attacks, which involved more than 400 drones and ten ballistic missiles, showed that the Russians were adopting “new tactics” by continuing raids into daytime hours, officials said. The governor of Kharkiv, an eastern region, said one person had been killed and a further 25 injured.

Cuba began releasing prisoners after announcing an amnesty for more than 2,000 inmates, the biggest in a decade. According to Reuters, a news agency, those freed appeared to be mostly people jailed for ordinary crimes. Whether political prisoners will be included—a key issue in talks with America—remains unclear; the Trump administration said it is closely monitoring who is released.

Myanmar’s parliament appointed Min Aung Hlaing, the head of the ruling junta, as the country’s president. The junta controls the legislature after a recent sham election. Since taking power in a coup in 2021, Min Aung Hlaing has lost control of much of the country in a violent uprising. He has formally stepped down from the army to become president, but has passed military power to an ally.

Figure of the day: 13 points, the average lead that the opposition Tisza party enjoys over Viktor Orban’s Fidesz ahead of Hungary’s election on April 12th, according to independent and opposition-allied polls. Read the full story.



Photograph: Getty Images

America’s volatile jobs market

Last year America’s jobs market lurched from strong to unsteady—and back again. Troubling months of payroll data were followed by reassuring ones. That volatility has largely carried on in 2026. January brought a surprisingly high number of new hires; February a low number. Figures released on Friday showed that March followed the trend. America’s economy added 178,000 jobs last month, much more than expected. The unemployment rate fell slightly, from 4.4% last month to 4.3%.

Until last month, jobs worries could well have nudged the Federal Reserve to cut interest rates. Even if Jerome Powell, the current chair, looked reluctant, his successor, Kevin Warsh, won Donald Trump’s nomination in large part by calling forcefully for cuts. Then, the president started bombing Iran. With oil prices surging and worries about inflation mounting, cuts are probably off the table for now. Markets reckon interest rates will remain unchanged this year.

Photograph: Getty Images

Kalshi’s high-stakes battle

America’s largest prediction-market site will need Lady Luck on its side when it grapples with two legal challenges against it on Friday. In Nevada, a court will decide whether to ban Kalshi, which offers sport, entertainment and election contracts, from operating in the state. In Arizona, where the firm faces criminal charges for running an “illegal gambling operation”, a judge will consider Kalshi’s plea for a federal court to block the case. Kalshi has called the charges “meritless”.

These are the latest clashes in a showdown between the marketplace and more than a dozen state regulators who want to bring the firm under their jurisdiction and subject it to local taxes. They argue that underneath the financial-market gloss, Kalshi is as much a gambling arena as any frontier saloon bar.

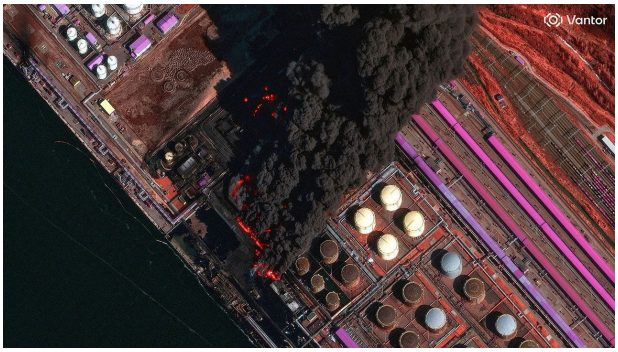
Kalshi is regulated by the Commodity Futures Trading Commission, a federal body overseeing futures and other derivatives. The firm has argued that this should trump state laws. Perhaps this will be the ace up its sleeve.

Photograph: Getty Images

Caracas after Maduro

There is a surreal feeling to Caracas, Venezuela's capital. Three months after the United States abducted Nicolás Maduro, the authoritarian president, the same regime (minus its head) is all hugs and handshakes with the Americans in town—who partly run the country. Giant photos of the former dictator hang over the motorways, and yet almost no one mentions him. Former political prisoners speak nervously about their experiences. Around 700 have been granted amnesty, but charges hang over many.

Amid the oddness and the misery, there is optimism. Members of Vente Venezuela, an opposition party, gather to discuss elections the organisers believe could be held in nine months. "This is the moment," one woman insists. Meanwhile in the plush Caracas Country Club, businesspeople are more cautious: the economy's prospects look brighter under the American-backed regime, they reason, so why risk the instability of an election so soon? The regime will want to play for time. Venezuelans may not be so patient.



Photograph: Reuters

Russia’s short-lived oil bonanza

Russia’s finance ministry published its monthly oil-and-gas revenue figures on Friday. The data reflects revenues based on oil prices before the Iran war: revenues were 617bn roubles ($7.7bn), 43% lower than the same month last year. But the numbers are likely to surge in the coming months: the value of Russian oil exports is estimated to have doubled in the first three weeks of March, as crude rose above $100 a barrel and America temporarily eased some restrictions on Russian oil. In April government oil-and-gas revenues are expected to reach around 900bn roubles ($11bn), the highest since October.

The boom may prove short-lived. Last week the Kremlin admitted it would be “difficult” to continue to meet such demand after Ukrainian drone strikes knocked out roughly 40% of Russia’s oil-export capacity. To prioritise domestic supply, the government has banned gasoline exports.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which American President pardoned Richard Nixon?

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

The really frightening thing about middle age is the knowledge that you'll grow out of it.

Doris Day